Grasping Straws?

an original deck of lateral-thinking prompts — print-and-play edition

1. Print pages 2–16 single-sided, on the heaviest stock your printer accepts.
2. Optional backs: put the printed sheets back in and print the last page on the reverse of each (long-edge flip).
3. Cut along the lines. A ruler and a blade beat scissors.
4. Shuffle. The 5 rules cards at the end are ways to play; the deck doesn't negotiate.

This free edition is for your own studio. The manufactured deck — real card stock, shuffled by your own hands — is the instrument; straws.lscaturchio.xyz has the details, the whole deck to read, and a card a day. Card texts © the deck's author.



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01

Solve the wrong problem beautifully.

02

Remove the part you rehearsed.

03

Do the last step first.

04

Halve it.
Then halve the half.

05

Make the transition
the destination.

06

Let the
accident audition.

07

Give the mistake
a name and a job.

08

Which rule are you obeying without being asked?

09

Trade your best idea for your strangest one.

10

Work at the speed of boredom.

11

Copy the structure; betray the content.

12

End earlier
than feels safe.

13

Abandon symmetry
mid-gesture.

14

Describe it to
someone who
cannot see it.

Build what you said.

15

Make it hospitable
to strangers.

16

What would this be at four in the morning?

17

Finish it badly, then defend the flaw.

18

Ask the least qualified person in the room.

That may be you.

19

Tune to the room, not the chart.

20

Play the chord
you can’t name.

21

Voice it in two notes.

22

Detune one string;
keep the fingering.

23

Let the drums lie
about the tempo.

24

The overtone
is the melody.

25

Treat the amp as
the instrument.

26

Record the rehearsal.
Discard the take.

27

What is the
silence doing?

28

Turn one
element to zero.

Notice what remains.

29

Hold the shot
until it confesses.

30

Weather is
a character.

Cast it.

31

Cut on the breath,
not the action.

32

Let the location rewrite the scene.

33

Show the aftermath; imply the event.

34

Water, smoke, or dust: choose one witness.

35

Light it for the room it used to be.

36

The frame is a door.

Which way
does it open?

37

Write the
footnote first.

38

Steal the syntax
of a prayer.

39

Say it once.

Trust the echo.

40

Translate it into plain speech; keep the ghost.

41

Delete every sentence you're proud of.

Read what's left.

42

Let a minor character narrate.

43

The obstacle is the initiation.

44

Descend,
retrieve, return.

You are on the
wrong step.

45

Read it as a cipher
for something kind.

46

What would the older
tradition call this?

47

Consult the dream,
then disobey it.

48

Cross the threshold facing backward.

49

Say it as a weather report.

50

Say it three times.

Change one word.

51

You are early.

Wait on the step.

52

What has to stay outside for you to go in?

HOW TO PLAY

TEN MINUTES

solo

Draw one card. Obey it — literally, not approximately — for ten minutes. No second draw. Keep the result or throw it away, but look at it first.

HOW TO PLAY

THREE STRAWS

solo

Deal three cards face down. Turn them in order: what is actually wrong; how to work on it; when to stop. Write the third one down.

HOW TO PLAY

FIRST & LAST

solo · one session

Draw before you begin and work under the card. When you believe you're done, draw exactly one more and let it edit the ending.

HOW TO PLAY

BLIND JURY

3 or more

One card for everyone, read aloud. No one says how they read it. Twenty minutes of work, then show the results side by side. Steal the best direction.

HOW TO PLAY

EXQUISITE RELAY

2 · over days or weeks

One piece, passed back and forth. Each pass begins with a secret draw. When the piece is finished, reveal the cards in order and title it with one.



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